Birds of Wellesley College

a journey to the colorful world of birds on campus



About this Zine

I created this zine during my Paulson Ecology of Place Internship in the summer of 2018. After spending time monitoring the bird boxes on campus, I became fascinated by the variety of birds at Wellesley. I hope to share my excitement about these birds with the rest of the Wellesley community.

Before coming into this internship, I had never spent time looking at birds, and I naively believed that all birds living near human occupied spaces are brown. Therefore I was thrilled to see a yellow warbler flying past me when I did my first bird watching on the wooden boardwalk near Lake Waban. Then during bird box monitoring, I encountered a family of black-capped chickadees using the bird boxes made by students from Wellesley's 3D design class. I realized how we are closely connected with other species who are sharing this landscape with us. I hope this zine can serve as a connection between the people of Wellesley and the landscape of Wellesley.

Han is a double major in Media Arts and Sciences and Math. She enjoys walking around Lake Waban, getting magic unicorn flavored ice cream from Lulu, and doing her work in the Media Lab.



Sorry...No penguin on campus...

Red-Winged Blackbird



Female
Slink through reeds and grasses collecting food or nest material.



Male
Sit on a high perch over their territories and sing their hearts out.

Migration
Resident or short-distance migrant. In MA all year round.
One of the most abundant birds across North America.

Habitat
They like to spend the breeding season in wet places like fresh or saltwater marshes.
They may also breed in drier places like sedge meadows, alfalfa fields, and fallow fields.
Occasionally, they nest in wooded areas along waterways.
In fall and winter, they congregate in agricultural fields, feedlots, pastures, and grassland.

Food
Summer, insects; winter, seeds including corn and wheat, and waste grains.



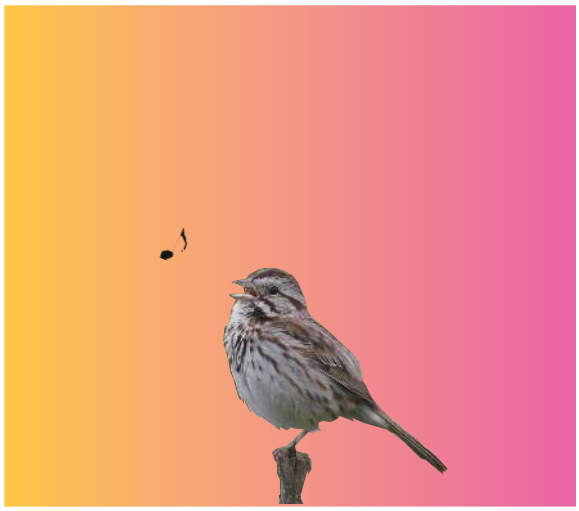
Red-Winged Black Bird [Locations where you are likely to find them.]

The return of the blackbirds to campus is an early sign of the coming spring, particularly around Paintshop Pond.

View on Campus:
All year

Song Sparrow





Habitat
Song Sparrows are found in an enormous variety of open habitats, including marshes, forest, agricultural fields, pastures, lake edges, forest edges, suburbs, and mixed woodlands.

Food
Song Sparrows eat both insects and plants. Prey include weevils, beetles, caterpillars, dragonflies, grasshoppers, spiders, snails, and earthworms. Plant foods include buckwheat, ragweed, clover, sunflower, wheat, rice, blackberries, blueberries, strawberries, raspberries, mulberries, and wild cherries. Food types vary greatly depending on what's common across the Song Sparrow's extensive range.



Nesting
Song Sparrow pairs search for nest sites together. Nest sites are usually hidden in grasses or weeds, sometimes placed on the ground and occasionally as high as 15 feet; often near water. Not afraid of human habitation, Song Sparrows may nest close to houses, in flower beds.

Migration
Birds from the northern U.S. may migrate, but typically don't go as far south as the birds that started from farther north.

Habits
Song Sparrows walk or hop on the ground and flit or hop through branches, grass, and weeds. Song Sparrows usually stay low and forage secretively, but males come to exposed perches, including limbs of small trees, to sing.



Song Sparrow [Locations where you are likely to find them.]

View on Campus:
All year



Blue Jay

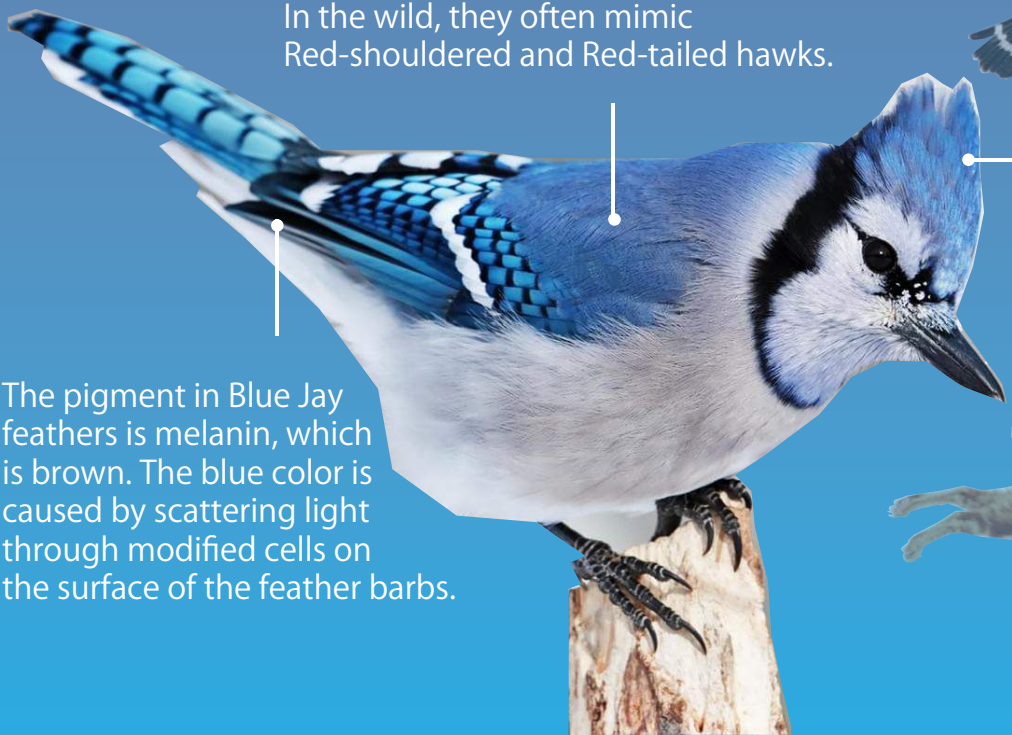
Habitat
Blue Jays are found in all kinds of forests but especially near oak trees.
They're common in urban and suburban areas, especially where oaks or bird feeders are found.

Food
Blue Jays eat insects, nuts, seeds, and grains.
They also take dead and injured small vertebrates.

Migration of Blue Jay is poorly understood.



Blue Jays are also excellent mimics. Captive Blue Jays sometimes learn to imitate human speech and meowing cats. In the wild, they often mimic Red-shouldered and Red-tailed hawks.



Blue Jays communicate with their crest. The higher the crest, the higher the bird's aggression level.

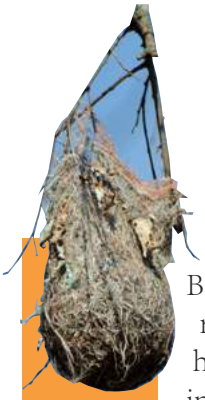
The pigment in Blue Jay feathers is melanin, which is brown. The blue color is caused by scattering light through modified cells on the surface of the feather barbs.





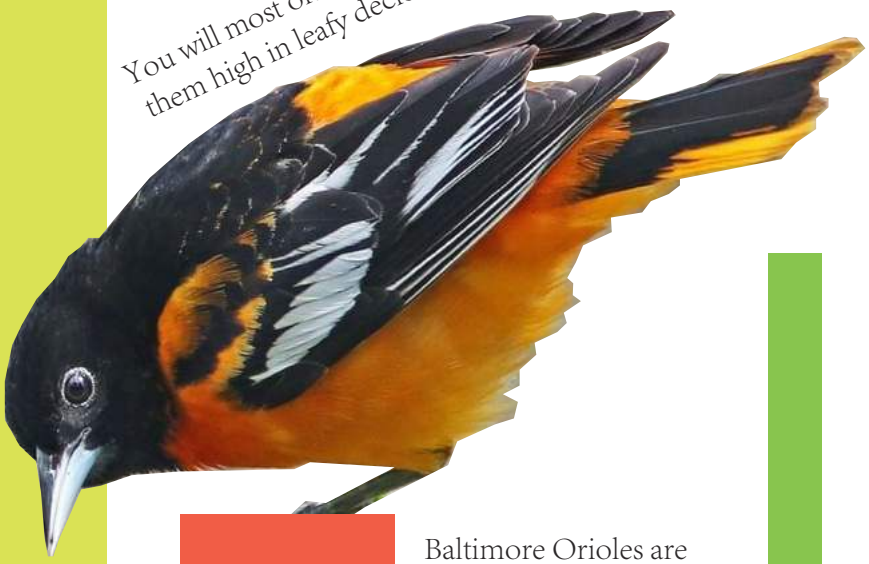
Blue Jay [Locations where you are likely to find them.]

View on Campus:
All year



Baltimore Orioles build remarkable, sock-like hanging nests high in a tree.

You will most often find them high in leafy deciduous tree.



Baltimore Orioles are easily lured to backyard feeders. Cut oranges in half and hang them from trees to invite orioles into your yard.

Habitat

They prefer open woodland, forest edge, river banks, small groves of trees. They have adapted well to human settlement and often feed and nest in parks, orchards, and backyards.

Food

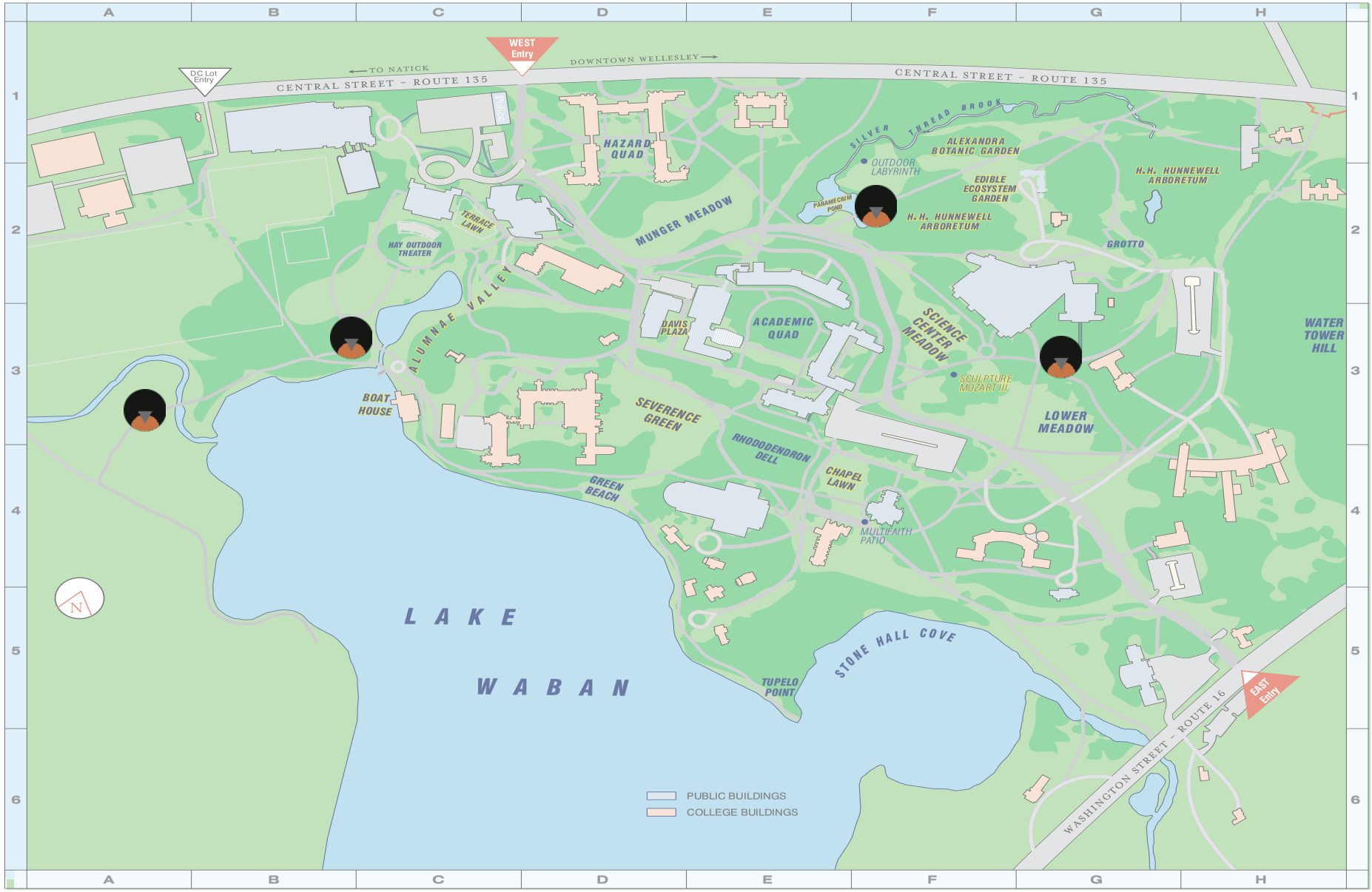
They eat more insects in summer to obtain the proteins needed for growth. In spring and fall their diet consists more of nectar and fruit to provide them fat and energy for migration. They love ripe, dark-colored fruit.



Migration

Baltimore Orioles arrive in MA around April to May, and leave around October for winter grounds in Florida, the Caribbean, Central America, and the northern tip of South America.

Baltimore Oriole



Baltimore Oriole [Locations where you are likely to find them.]

There was a nest of Baltimore Oriole at Paramecium Pond in past years.

View on Campus:
April - October

Black-capped Chickadee



Curious about everything, including human.
Chickadees are active, acrobatic, curious, social birds that live in flocks.

Migration

Adult chickadees do not migrate. Young birds might move irregularly.

Habitat

Deciduous and mixed forests, open woods, parks, willow thickets, cottonwood groves, and disturbed areas.



Food

In winter Black-capped Chickadees eat about half seeds, berries, and other plant matter, and half animal food like insects, spiders, etc.
In spring, summer, and fall, insects, spiders, and other animal food make up 80-90 percent of their diet.



Blackcapped Chickadee [Locations where you are likely to find them.]

They can be found nesting in the spring in the bird box near Mungar meadow.

View on Campus:
All year

Habitat

Weedy fields, open floodplains, particularly with sunflower, aster, and thistle plants for food and some shrubs and trees for nesting. Goldfinches are also common in suburbs, parks, and backyards.

American Goldfinches are active, acrobatic finches that balance on the seedheads of thistles, dandelions, and other plants to pluck seeds. They have a bouncy flight during which they frequently make their "po-ta-to-chip" calls.



Breeding male

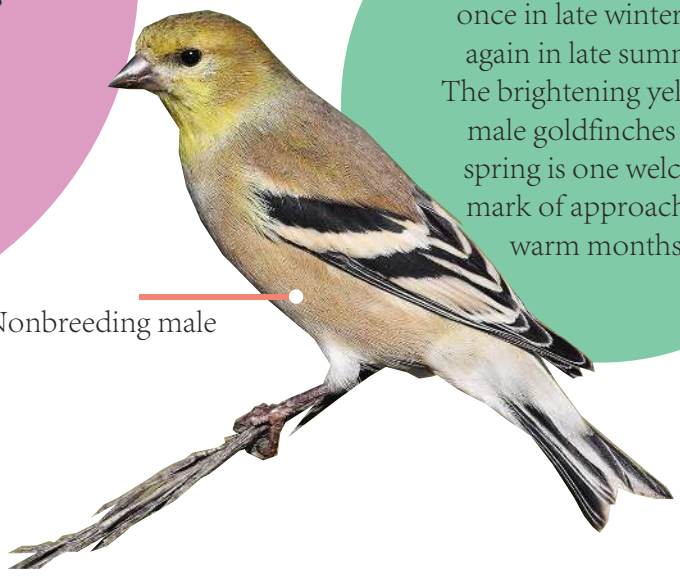
Migration

Short distance migrant. In MA all year round.

Food

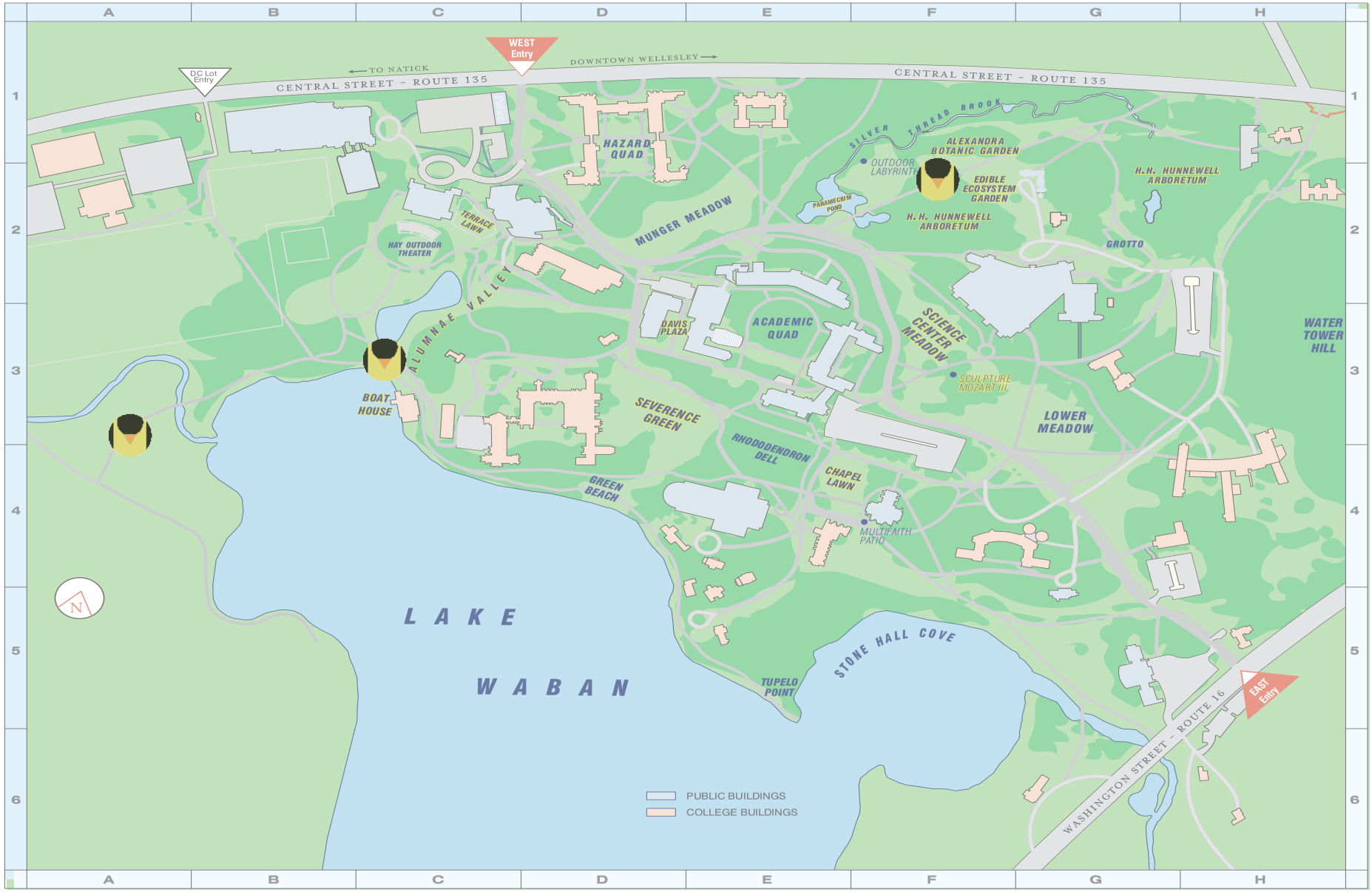
Goldfinches are among the strictest vegetarians in the bird world, electing an entirely vegetable diet and only inadvertently swallowing an occasional insect. Main types of seeds come from sunflowers, thistle, asters, and trees such as alder, birch, and elm. At feeders they prefers nyjer and sunflower.

They molt their body feathers twice a year, once in late winter and again in late summer. The brightening yellow of male goldfinches each spring is one welcome mark of approaching warm months.



Nonbreeding male

American Goldfinch



American Goldfinch [Locations where you are likely to find them.]

View on Campus:
All year

Yellow Warbler

North America has more than 50 species of warblers,
but few combine brilliant color
and easy viewing quite like the Yellow Warbler.

Migration

In MA during breeding season.

Habitat

Yellow Warblers spend the breeding season in thickets and
other disturbed or regrowing habitats, particularly along streams and wetlands.
They are often found among willows but also live in dwarf birch stands in the tundra,
among aspen trees in the Rockies, and along the edges of fields in the East,
where you may find them among alder or dogwood as well as orchards,
blueberry bogs, and overgrown power-line cuts.

Food

Yellow Warblers eat mostly insects that they pick from foliage
or capture on short flights or while hovering to reach leaves.
Typical prey include midges, caterpillars, beetles, leafhoppers and other bugs, and wasps.



Look for Yellow Warblers near the tops of tall
shrubs and small trees.
Males sing their sweet,
whistled songs from high perches.



Yellow Warbler [Locations where you are likely to find them.]

A small population of yellow warblers was in the wetland near Paintshop Pond before its reconstruction.

View on Campus:
April - October



American Robin

Habitat
You'll find American Robins on lawns, fields, and city parks, as well as in more wild places like woodlands, forests, and mountains up to near treeline. During winter many robins move to moist woods where berry-producing trees and shrubs are common.

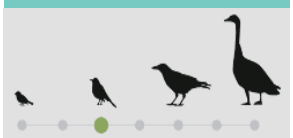
Food
American Robins eat large numbers of both invertebrates and fruit. Particularly in spring and summer they eat large numbers of earthworms as well as insects and some snails. They also eat an enormous variety of fruits, including chokecherries, hawthorn, and juniper berries, etc. When they eat honeysuckle berries exclusively, they sometimes become intoxicated.

Migration

Resident or short-distance migrant. Robins can be found year round in MA.

Fun Fact

Robins make a good reference point for comparing the size and shape of other birds.



Habits

When foraging on the ground, the American Robin runs a few steps, then stops abruptly. In long grass, robins may hop or fly just above the ground powered by slow, powerful wingbeats.

During fall and winter robins often roost in large flocks and spend much more time in trees. In spring, males attract females by singing, raising and spreading their tails, shaking their wings and inflating their white-striped throats.



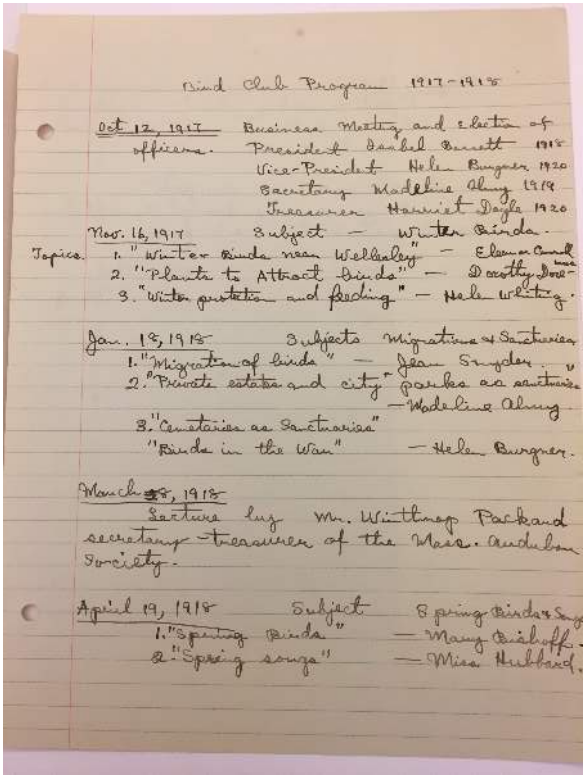


American Robin [Locations where you are likely to find them.]

View on Campus:
All year

1918

From the Archives, we found Wellesley College Bird Club program notes from 1917 - 1918. In the program, the topics discussed include “Winter Birds near Wellesley,” “Plants to Attract Birds,” “Spring Songs,” “Nests and Nesting Places,” and “Birds in the War.”



Bird Club Program 1917-1918

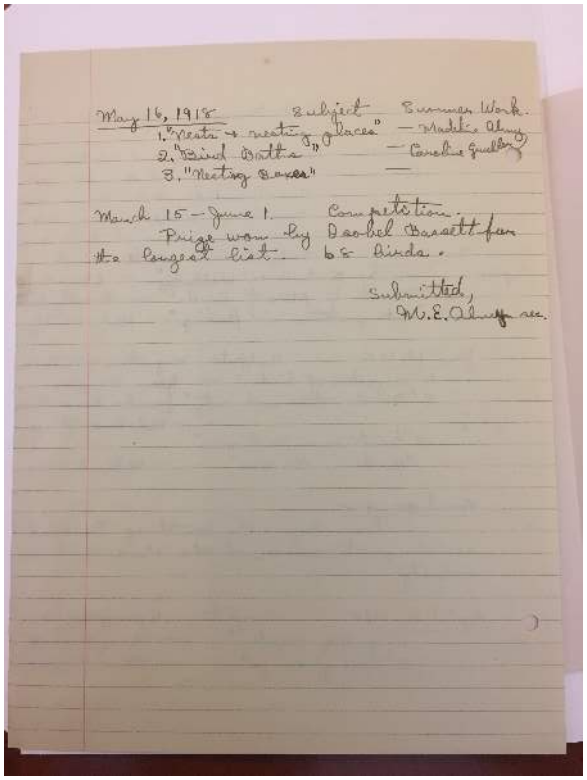
Oct. 12, 1917 Business Meeting and election of officers. President Daobel Bassett 1918
Vice-President Helen Burgner 1920
Secretary Madeline Almy 1919
Treasurer Harriet Doyle 1920

Nov. 16, 1917 Subject — Winter Birds.
Topics 1. "Winter Birds near Wellesley" — Eleanor Cook
2. "Plants to Attract Birds" — Dorothy Doe
3. "Winter protection and feeding" — Helen Whiting.

Jan. 18, 1918 Subjects Migrations & Sanctuaries
1. "Migration of birds" — Jean Snyder.
2. "Private estates and city parks as sanctuaries" —Madeline Almy.
3. "Cemeteries as Sanctuaries"
"Birds in the War" — Helen Burgner.

March 18, 1918
Lecture by Mr. Winthrop Packard secretary-treasurer of the Mass. Audubon Society.

April 19, 1918 Subject Spring Birds & Songs
1. "Spring Birds" — Mary Bishoff.
2. "Spring songs" — Miss Hubbard.



May 16, 1918 Subject Summer Work.
1. "Nests & nesting places" — Madeline Almy
2. "Bird Baths" — Caroline Quelch
3. "Nesting Boxes" —

March 15 – June 1. Competition.
Prize won by Daobel Bassett for the largest list. 65 Birds.

Submitted,
M. E. Almy sec.

2018

Today, 100 years later, students at Wellesley are still connecting with the landscape. Last semester, students from professor Andrew Mowbray's three-dimensional design class built 14 bird boxes for different species of birds on campus. This summer, the Paulson Ecology of Place Initiative interns monitored the bird boxes on campus. Here are pictures from bird monitoring.



Baby Robins
Photo by: Jessica Ostfield '20

Black-capped Chickadee
Photo by: Suzanne Langridge





Tree Frog
Photo by: Suzanne Langridge



Tree Swallow
Photo by: Suzanne Langridge

Other great resources for learning about birds:
iNaturalist: An App for identifying and recording plants and animals.
The Cornell Lab Merlin: An app for bird identification with many pictures and audio recordings of bird calls.
Ebird: An online program that provides data sources on bird abundance and distribution at spatial and temporal scales.

All information and most pictures from this zine come from The Cornell Lab of Ornithology. For more information please visit their website at http://www.birds.cornell.edu.

Wellesley College Bird Club documents come from the Wellesley College Archives Library and Technology Services.

Acknowledgements

A huge thank you to the Paulson Ecology of Place Initiative, my supervisor Suzanne Langridge; Rebecca Goldman and Sara Ludovissy from the Archives; Sarah Hoskins and Rebecca Darling from LTS; Marci Hahn-Fabris from Digital Collections; Kristina Jones, Jennifer Yang, and all of the interns/research students from the Botanic Gardens.



Eastern Bluebird
View on Campus: All year

Cedar Waxwing
View on Campus: All year



